

Sona Dheep Raja Balaji

Interaction Designer · UX Researcher

Sydney, Australia · sonadheep@gmail.com · 0425 331 587

[linkedin.com/in/sona-dheep-raja-balaji-335263168](https://www.linkedin.com/in/sona-dheep-raja-balaji-335263168)

PROFILE

Interaction designer and UX researcher in the final year of a Master of Interaction Design at UTS, with five years as a senior software engineer in test behind it. I run research end to end, recruiting participants, moderating interviews, coding transcripts, usability testing and heuristic evaluation and carry findings through to high-fidelity prototypes and working builds in SwiftUI, p5.js and Unity. Having spent five years testing what other people shipped, I design with the constraints of the build in mind, and I am comfortable being the person who removes a feature when the evidence says so.

SELECTED DESIGN PROJECTS

Liminality - OzCHI 2026 Student Design Challenge

Sep 2026

38th Australian Conference on Computer-Human Interaction, Adelaide · Team of four · In progress

- Designing Memory Garden, an iPad experience where a grieving child and family build a shared “butterfly” of memories, treating grief as a liminal space rather than a problem to solve.
- Translated childhood-grief literature and a risk analysis into design principles, attributed memories, clear exits and prototyped it in SwiftUI.

Qrew - Community app for LGBTQ+ people

Feb – May 2026

Interaction Design Studio, UTS · Six Lean UX sprints · Team project

- Planned and ran usability testing on the mid-fidelity prototype, documenting findings across all four features, map, buddy matching, chat, and reviews and ratings and communicating results to the team and in class presentations.
- Followed testing with a heuristic evaluation against Nielsen's heuristics, isolating root causes rather than symptoms: a missing map legend violating recognition over recall, and no cancel option in buddy matching violating user control.
- Recruited field study participants after the team's standard channels returned almost no engagement, posting a detailed, consent-led call into a Sydney LGBTQ+ community group; ran two interviews and coded both transcripts into an affinity diagram, identifying five major themes.
- Argued for removing the buddy rating feature after participants described it as surveillance dressed up as protection, and moved reviews onto event hosts instead. Reframed the product problem from finding events to reducing the barriers to walking in alone.
- Built a 27-product competitor analysis locating Qrew's market gap, and delivered the high-fidelity Events and Event Detail screens for the MVP panel pitch.

Snippets - iOS journaling app

2026

iOS Innovation Studio, UTS · Group concept, individual build · Swift / SwiftUI

- Owned an individual value variation, Mindfulness through Intentional Pausing, and built the app individually in Swift after the group design phase.
- Designed three full-screen moments, Pause, Breathe, and Look Around You, sitting between receiving a prompt and opening the camera, plus emotion logging through colour that accumulates into a visual record over time.
- Ran a trade-off analysis and deliberately removed streaks, checklists and reward systems, on the research finding that adults lacked permission to slow down rather than creativity.
- A single usability session showed the generative emotion artwork read as decoration because nothing on screen connected it to logged emotions; added a confirmation screen that existed nowhere in the Figma file.

WeConnect - Social connection app for adults aged 65–75

Jul 2026

Apple Foundation Program · Team capstone · Figma, Xcode, SwiftUI

- Owned the high-fidelity prototype: the visual design system, screen-by-screen UI, and interaction design.
- Contributed to desk research on social isolation and technology accessibility, market research, and primary interviews with domain experts and people in the target age group.
- Translated research findings into concrete accessibility decisions, voice-first input, plain language over jargon, colour always paired with a redundant cue, and generous tap targets.
- Held the line on a finding that shaped everything: the product must never present itself as being for elderly people, because users reject being labelled and set apart.

Sensing Home - Cultural probe study

2025

Human-Centred Design Research Methods, UTS · Solo research

- Designed a multisensory probe kit engaging touch, smell, sound and drawing, after an interview study revealed participants could not put sensory food memories into words at all - standard diary and interview methods would have missed the finding entirely.

- Ran pre- and post-probe interviews with a migrant participant and analysed the results into a peer-formatted research paper and accompanying video.
- Found that a single sense cascades into others, with smell and sound proving stronger triggers than the expected taste, and that physical responses during cooking were retained as embodied memory.

Threads of Taste & Memory - Interactive data visualisation

2025

Creative coding · p5.js · Solo

- Built an interactive piece where each migrant food memory is a Bézier curve running from a home country to Australia, with hover-to-reveal memory text and click-to-play audio backed by a text-to-speech fallback.
- Designed the interaction around a single gesture: pressing a key reweaves the scattered threads into the word HOME.

Cap it Hot! - Unity platformer

May 2026

Computer Game Design, UTS · Team of four

- Designed and built levels 0 and 1 of a game in which a mug races to assemble a cappuccino before the temperature runs out.
- Worked the brief's theme constraints into mechanics rather than decoration: slippery surfaces, rush-hour zones, ice blocks and pressure zones combine into a continuous risk-management system.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Senior Software Engineer in Test - Freshworks

Jul 2019 – Aug 2024

Chennai, India

- Led a QA team - designing test plans, mentoring engineers, and aligning development, product and design teams.
- Drove automation testing in Ruby and Selenium, doubling test coverage with near-zero bug leakage.
- Owned end-to-end testing for Agent Management features across API, UI, regression and load testing, sustaining 95%+ pass rates.
- Built Jenkins CI/CD pipelines for nightly regression and co-developed a Wiremock-based stub product.
- Acted as squad lead for task grooming, staging and production deployments, and cross-team knowledge transfer.

EDUCATION

Master of Interaction Design in Information Technology

Feb 2025 – Present

University of Technology Sydney · Final year, third semester

B.Tech, Computer Science & Engineering

Jul 2015 – Apr 2019

Sastra University, India

SKILLS & TOOLS

Research Participant recruitment, interview moderation, usability testing, heuristic evaluation, cultural probes, thematic analysis and transcript coding, affinity diagramming, competitor analysis, personas, journey mapping.

Design Figma, Adobe XD, Miro, Canva. Wireframing, high-fidelity prototyping, design systems, accessible interface design.

Build Swift and SwiftUI, p5.js, Unity, HTML, CSS, Python.

Quality engineering Selenium, Ruby, Jenkins CI/CD, API, load, regression and performance testing, Agile and Scrum.

Collaboration Jira, Trello, Freshrelease, Lean UX sprints, design critique, cross-functional facilitation.

ADDITIONAL EXPERIENCE

Customer Service - Anita Gelato

Aug 2026 – Present

Sydney

- Serve a high volume of customers through peak trading, recommending flavours from a large range, operating the POS and handling cash and card at pace, and keeping queues moving without losing the warmth.
- Restock and monitor displays, hold food safety and hygiene standards across the service area, and work a shared roster including evenings and weekends.

Support Worker, casual - Mable

Feb 2025 – Jan 2026

Sydney

- In-home support for clients aged 80+, managing multiple client schedules, calendar coordination, family liaison and digital record keeping.
- Sustained close contact with the age group most products overlook, which directly informed design decisions on WeConnect.

Pantry Volunteer - Bluebird Pantry, UTS

Feb – May 2026

- Daily pantry operations, stock monitoring and student-facing service in a high-demand environment.

INTERESTS

Fantasy novels · Travelling and exploring new cultures · Creating art across multiple mediums